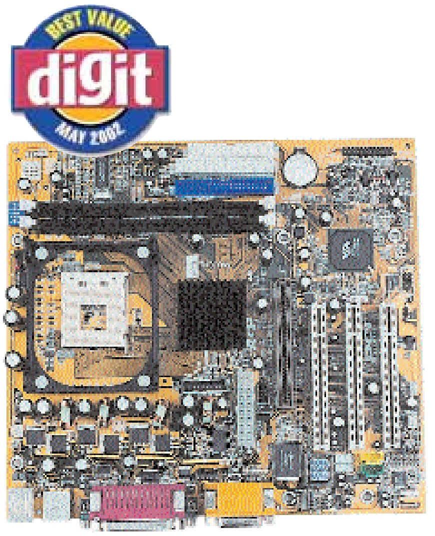

***HIS P4M266 (M50-12)**: Plenty of bang for the buck in a small form factor*

***ASUS A7V266-E**: Great performance with plenty of room for tweaking*

***Krypton M7VKS**: Unbeatable combination of features and price*

However, there are no bundled extras save the flash utility for upgrading the BIOS and a copy of PC-Cillin anti-virus software. The manual was very simple, listing only the main motherboard specifications. The CPU core voltage is set via DIP switches, which means you have to set them prior to installing the motherboard inside the cabinet.

***Our Verdict:** A great board if you want an inexpensive Pentium 4 SDRAM solution.*

ASUS A7V266-E

This board from ASUS uses the VIA KT266A DDR chipset with support for the AMD Athlon Thunderbird, Athlon XP and Duron Socket-A processors. It features five PCI slots, an AGP Pro slot, which is rather rare, and supports up to 3 GB of memory. The onboard audio is capable of delivering HRTF 3D surround sound using the C-Media CMI8738 audio chip.

The board is well laid out and there is a lot of space around the processor socket for attaching a bigger heat sink. Overclocking is controlled via the BIOS or by using the DIP switches provided on the board. The board comes with a detailed manual and a quick reference card, which is useful for the impatient enthusiasts. In our tests the board was very stable and provided some great results.

***Our Verdict:** Recommended for the performance enthusiasts; uses the tried and tested VIA KT266A chipset.*

Krypton M7VKS

The M7VKS is a VIA KM133A-based board for Athlon XP processors using SDRAM. This board is a good solution for AMD processors as it scored fairly well in all our benchmarks. The motherboard includes integrated graphics (using the Trident Blade 3D chip) and does not feature an AGP slot. This makes it an ideal solution for low-cost Duron systems that don't need high-end graphics performance.

It features two DIMM slots and was the only motherboard that came with an ISA slot. The M7VKS has onboard sound, hardware monitoring for system temperature and fan speed, and comes in a Micro-ATX format.

***Our Verdict:** This board is a great option if you plan on buying a low-cost Duron or Athlon system.*

ASUS TUSL2-M

The ASUS TUSL2-M uses the Intel 815EP chipset and is by far the best board for the Intel Tualatin processors, trashing every other board in its category. In *Quake III Arena* it managed a very commendable score of 206 fps when clubbed with a GeForce3 graphics card. It registered the highest score (in this category) in

New Technologies on the Horizon

Performance is going up across the board with the arrival of technologies like Serial ATA, which is set to replace the aged Parallel ATA interface in use today. Serial ATA, in its initial *avatar*, will run at a whopping 150 MBps, or almost twice as fast as standard ATA. Serial ATA will use more compact four-conductor cables than the 40/80-conductor cables in use today.

Memory technologies are set for a significant overhaul as DDR SDRAM will move to a much faster DDR II 400 (6.4 GBps theoretical bandwidth) and RDRAM will also move up from the current PC800 to PC1066, offering a whopping 4.5 GBps of effective bandwidth.

Next up is PCI-X, which takes the existing 32-bit PCI technology and moves it to 64-bits. This will lead to increases in both throughput and clock speed. This pumped up PCI specification operates at speeds of up to 133 MHz (versus the current 33 MHz).

But topping all this is the AGP 8x standard, which will debut with the next generation of graphics cards and will run at 533 MHz. This makes even the GeForce 4 running at AGP 4x look pale in comparison.